

Working Backwards — Four Vignettes

Day 2 · Activity 1 handout. Four short accounts of how a product was conceived. For each, decide: was this **forward-built** (tool/feature first) or **backward-built** (customer outcome first)? Name the evidence. Two of the four are designed to mislead — read carefully. For each, write the **one question** that, if asked earlier, would have changed the outcome.

Vignette A

A dispatch-tool founder, after hearing customers complain about mobile app speed, built a native iOS rewrite over two quarters. At launch, 40% of techs still used the web view because they'd switched to Android mid-project.

Vignette B

A PM wrote a one-page mock press release for "OfflineFirst Ticket Capture" and circulated it to five techs for reaction. Three said they'd already built paper workarounds; two said the app's login flow was the real blocker. The PR was re-scoped to login before offline.

Vignette C

Engineering discovered a faster map-tile rendering library and shipped it as a mid-sprint improvement. Dispatcher satisfaction bumped 12 points in the next survey.

Vignette D

A PM drafted a PR/FAQ for "Tech-First Messaging" and had AI generate three customer quotes. The quotes all used marketing language no tech would say. The PM skipped persona research and shipped anyway.

For each vignette

1. **Forward-built or backward-built?**
2. **What's the evidence?**

3. **The one question** that, asked earlier, would have changed the outcome:
